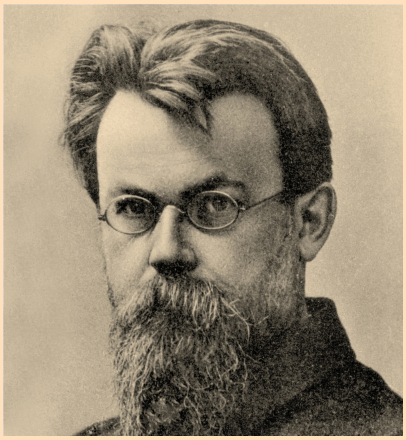
Vladimir Vernadsky



Born in 1863, Vladimir Vernadsky graduated from St. Petersburg State University aged 22, and did postgraduate work in Italy and Germany, where he studied the optical, elastic, magnetic, thermal, and electrical properties of crystals. After the revolution in Russia in February 1917, Vernadsky became assistant Minister of Education in the provisional government. The following year, he founded the Ukrainian Academy of Science in Kiev. Although his book *The Biosphere* was not taken seriously by scientists outside Russia for many years, it later became one of the founding documents of Gaia theory.

In the 1930s, Vernadsky advocated the use of nuclear power, and played an advisory role in the development of the Soviet atomic bomb project. He died in 1945.

Key works

1924 *Geochemistry*

1926 *The Biosphere*

1943 "The Biosphere and the Noosphere"

1944 "Problems of Biochemistry"

See also: The ecosystem • Biodiversity and ecosystem function • A holistic view of Earth • The Gaia hypothesis